

FundAccess, and Fidelity's FundsNetwork. Many large brokerages have similar offerings.

What to Know Before You Shop

(NAV) Net assets value, which is a fund's assets minus liabilities, is the value of a mutual fund. NAV per share is the value of one share in the mutual fund, and it is the number that is quoted in newspapers. You can basically just think of NAV per share as the price of a mutual fund. It fluctuates everyday as fund holdings and shares outstanding change.

When you buy shares, you pay the current NAV per share plus any sales front-end load. When you sell your shares, the fund will pay you NAV less any back-end load.

Finding Funds

Nearly every fund company in the country also has its own website. Simply type the name of the fund or Fund Company that you wish to learn more about into a search engine and hit "search." If you don't have a specific fund company already in mind, you can run a search for terms like "no-load small cap fund" or large-cap value fund."

For a more organized search, there are a variety of other resources available online. Two notable ones include:

The Mutual Fund Education Alliance is the not-for-profit trade association of the no-load mutual fund industry. They have a tool for searching for no-load funds.